

What is a jewel?

A jewel is a precious stone, usually a single crystal or part of a hard, lustrous or translucent mineral that has been cut or shaped for decorative use, and typically set into a metal or other precious material – either as jewellery to be worn or as an ornamental object. Jewels and jewellery have been created since prehistoric times and rank among some of the earliest known artefacts. In

some cases, jewellery has originated in functional objects, such as brooches to fasten clothing. Some adornments had talismanic meaning, while in many cultures, jewellery and bejewelled objects were a means of storing wealth and indicating social standing. Below is a selection of jewellery and jewelled ornaments from prehistory to the modern world, covering a wide range of uses.



Mesolithic shell necklace

This necklace of snail shell beads found in Serbia is almost 10,000 years old, and is among early evidence of ornamental jewellery.

Lapis lazuli feathers

Egyptian falcon pectoral

Symbol of the sun god Horus, this gold, cornelian, and lapis lazuli pectoral is from the tomb of Amenemope, c.1000BCE.



Chinese deer pendant

This 1st-millennium BCE animal carving is of highly prized nephrite.



Cornelian insets



Babylonian gold pendant

One of a pair, this pendant from the 2nd millennium BCE represents the minor goddess Lama.



Griffin (half lion, half eagle)

Hippocamp (sea horse)



Greek fibula

Found in Crimea, this hollow gold fibula (brooch) dates from c.425–400 BCE, and depicts a mythical hippocamp and griffin.

